

ALPHA MALE: Mallya and team in the F1 pit lane at the Australian GP

then, though a spokesperson said, "the letters of credit are in place and we are at a very initial stage". No site has been chosen nor has Tilke been contacted about a track design. Everything looks generously fluid when compared to the planning around this season's F1 debutantes, Singapore.

Early discussions around the Singapore GP, which will be held on September 28 over a street circuit, began as early as mid-2006. Other than installing a temporary lights system for the first-ever F1 night race, Singapore GP officials are building 1.2 km of new roads and a permanent new pit building.

Fiona Smith, Singapore GP communications manager told INDIA TODAY that Singapore's timescales were considered tight, "We are achieving in 18 months, what many Grand Prix organisers work for two years to create." In fact, China took 18 months to build an F1 track in Shanghai with 20,000 men including 3,000 engineers working around the clock. India should probably be slightly further down the road than letters of credit. Jaypee executives though, believe a year is enough to get an F1 track race ready. "We've done hydro-electric projects in the hills, an F1 track is essentially a flat road," one said.

Nazir Hoosein, former F1 permanent steward, vice-president of the FIA (the world governing body for all motorsport) and portfolio holder for Asia and Oceania, warns, "F1 is not a small circus, it's a very large circus." Eight or nine jumbo loads of equipment fly in to F1 venues, the FIA itself moving 10 tonnes between circuit stops. Most F1 venues have three-to-four lane highways from airport to track to move the equipment.

The average requirement of three-to four-star hotel rooms for an F1 race, says Hoosein, is 7,500. Even if the numbers were halved, the National Capital Region does not yet meet these requirements. "I don't want to sound like I'm against an F1 race in India," says Hoosein, "but requirements have to be met. If they're on the calendar, then the race has got to start on time." The

FORCE INDIA F1



NEXT IN LINE: Chandhok was invited to test with the Red Bull Racing F1 team in November 2007

A1GP ARRIVISTES

A1GP calls itself the World Cup of Motorsport and runs in the winter, just as the F1 season winds down.

■ The A1GP is now finishing its third season, running from September to May, 22 cars competing over 10 races in 2007-08.

■ Cars compete not the flags of countries, not teams of automotive corporations. Unlike in F1, the cars are provided by A1GP, levelling the field and giving technical expertise and driving skill more of a say than big budgets.

■ The A1GP cars have 550bhp Zytek engines. Teams are given the cars on the Wednesday morning before the race weekend. After every race the cars are packed up and moved to the next venue.

■ The cost of staging an A1GP race is no more than \$20m. The operational budget of an A1GP team starts at \$5m a year.

Formula 1 is one of the world's most exclusive clubs, while the fledgling A1 sells itself on accessibility and affordability.